

Chapter 57-4

While Xu Qingzhu was refreshing the trending topics, Lin Luoxi asked in confusion: "What kind of trending topics could those two buy for you? About the restroom incident last time?"

Sally said: "But wasn't it obviously Bai Junior's fault that time?"

"Those who mix in the entertainment industry don't just have dirty hearts." Lin Luoxi had already seen the video and sneered. "Their methods are dirty too."

Sally: "?"

But no one came to answer Sally's question.

After Xu Qingzhu finished watching the video and those fabricated articles by marketing accounts, she only felt a chill down her spine.

She had never imagined that one day, she would encounter Bai Weiwei online in such a way.

She closed her eyes, wanting to send a message on her phone but found her hands were shaking. She took a deep breath, suppressing her bad emotions and trying to think about the problem as calmly as possible.

Just as she was about to search for the recording in her phone to send out, there was a knock on the office door.

It was the head of the PR department. "Vice President Xu, have you seen the trending topics?"

"I've seen them." Xu Qingzhu resumed her cool and indifferent demeanor. "I acted in self-defense and accidentally hurt someone. I didn't intentionally hit her, nor did I abuse my power, so this matter can be turned around."

"The sales department just contacted me, saying that because of this trending topic, our autumn collection's sales have obviously declined. There are also many of Chen Liuying's fans coming to return products and leave bad reviews. This matter must be handled as much as possible." The PR department head said: "But since it involves you, I still hope to get your opinion."

Before the words finished, a voice suddenly interrupted: "Sales decline? Which products?"

The PR department head was startled, but because of the oppressive tone in that voice, he instinctively answered: "All the products that went online today."

Sally was there watching the excitement unfold, saying gleefully: "Zhou Yi'an, your most proud work is included."

Zhou Yi'an had one hand in her pocket, a black denim jacket casually draped over her body—a very casual outfit that she wore with exceptional charm. Irritation flashed in her eyes, then her gaze passed over the PR department head to look at Xu Qingzhu. "Was it your bestie who did this?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She steadied herself, cleared her throat lightly, and said to the PR department head: "Let's go, meeting time."

She had the recording from that day, so she wasn't afraid.

Lin Luoxi and Zhou Yi'an both requested to attend the meeting.

Xu Qingzhu originally only wanted to meet with the PR department people, but seeing Lin Luoxi's expression, she guessed she might have some better ideas, so she agreed.

As for Zhou Yi'an.

Using her characteristically arrogant tone, she said: "My work's sales are affected, shouldn't I be involved?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Just as they entered the meeting room, Liang Shi's call came through again.

"Where are you now?" Liang Shi inquired.

"The company." Xu Qingzhu answered. "We're about to hold a related meeting for PR."

"The online public opinion has already fermented significantly, and the battle has even spread to Dongheng. Second Brother is with me now. We're coming to find you to align our stories." Liang Shi tactfully reminded: "After all, you now have another identity¹."

Xu Qingzhu understood her implication. "Got it."

She opened her computer and kept refreshing the trending topics.

The topic about her hitting someone had already reached first place, completely stealing the buzz from 《Afterglow》's official announcement.

What Liang Shi meant by "the battle spreading to Dongheng" was that someone had dug up her relationship with Liang Shi. They didn't drag Liang Shi into it, but they did reveal that she was the third young master's wife of Dongheng Group.

So online criticism now included Dongheng as well.

There were also many people fishing in troubled waters².

Saying that the third young lady of the Liang family was originally a wastrel³—arrogant, domineering, and imperious. Two people sleeping in the same bed wouldn't produce different personalities, so it was understandable that Xu Qingzhu would do such things.

And netizens felt even more pity for Chen Liuying.

She was already beaten but could still maintain her smile.

Truly, actors couldn't compete with capital.

Everyone seemed to have forgotten that after Chen Liuying's agent's suicide incident, they had furiously criticized them for kowtowing to capital.

But none of this mattered now.

Online opinions were boiling. In this battle of public opinion, Xu Qingzhu was at the center of the storm.

First they criticized her for being arrogant, then they dug up her identity as Dongheng's young mistress.

Subsequently, gossip emerged about her marrying into Dongheng to obtain financing, and claims about her chaotic private life during school, frequently leading on suitors and keeping a pond full of fish⁴.

In short, what everyone was originally arguing about no longer mattered.

They had gone too far down the path of eating melons⁵, having long forgotten why they started.

The office atmosphere was deathly still.

Meanwhile, Sally was quietly making big moves outside, posting on Weibo in her not-so-fluent Chinese: [Compared to her, Blanche is obviously more beautiful and more delicate. Why would you say Blanche hit someone? When our Blanche was in school, she couldn't bear to step on even an ant.]

Marketing accounts quickly reposted her Weibo and defined it as: Friend speaks out.

Netizens also rushed to her Weibo comments:

[Someone who couldn't bear to step on an ant dares to hit people?]

[They're all dogs raised by capital, what wouldn't they dare to do?]

[Being beautiful and delicate could also mean being a green tea bitch⁶! Just because she's pretty means she can hit people?]

[Can I slap you because I'm good-looking?]

[...]

Footnotes: ¹ Another identity: Referring to Xu Qingzhu's status as the wife of Liang Shi (third young master of Dongheng Group) ² Fishing in troubled waters: Taking advantage of chaotic situations for personal gain ³ Wastrel: A spoiled, irresponsible person from a wealthy family ⁴ Keeping a pond full of fish: Slang for leading on multiple romantic interests simultaneously ⁵ Eating melons: Chinese internet slang for consuming gossip and drama ⁶ Green tea bitch: Slang for someone who appears innocent and pure but is actually manipulative

